economy and reduce reliance on India. By working with China, these countries seek to increase their strategic autonomy and are naturally concerned about any Indian balancing initiative that could fuel Chinese resentment, especially on security and defence cooperation. In 2018, for example, Nepal's government pulled out of a BIMSTEC disaster response exercise hosted by India due to domestic pressure that portrayed it as a "military alliance" targeting China.[11] For Delhi, it has, therefore, become imperative to find a way to engage these countries beyond seeking to rope them into balancing efforts or initiatives that exclude China.

Both challenges illustrate how India is facing rising incentives to invest in its soft power to distinguish itself from China and, at the same time, seek to reassure its smaller neighbours and other states that are hedging their bets between Delhi and Beijing. Such efforts are not new, with India's investment in a modernised public diplomacy dating back to the late 2000s. But the global rise of China in recent years, in tandem with the ascent of Prime Minister Modi and the nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to power, seems to have further reinforced India's *strategic* approach to soft power. As noted by Ian Hall, "the rise of China is one of the major reasons for [India's] rush to build capacity in public diplomacy."[12]

In a statement to the Indian parliament in 2017, India's former Foreign Secretary (and current External Affairs Minister) S. Jaishankar emphasised this new strategy by underlining India's soft power in exceptionalist terms, in contrast both with China and the West:

> Large countries have unique soft power. We will have a mix which would be very different though we are Asian countries, say from China, though we are democracy say from Europe or the United States. I think we are in a